Los Angeles Times

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GABRIEL V. CARDENAS For The Times

PEOPLE turn out for a parade Saturday in support of Democratic candidate Bobby Pulido in Edinburg, Texas.

Trump points his fraud allegations at immigrants

The administration's claims have ramped up as the midterm elections draw near.

BY ANDREA CASTILLO

WASHINGTON — President Trump has alleged that elections, public benefit programs and federal grants to nonprofits are rife with fraud. Now, he is increasingly focusing on fraud in his effort to detain and deport more immigrants.

Recent, high-profile flash points include 28 lawful permanent residents accused this week of illegally voting in California and the federal investigation into Somali-born Rep. Ilhan Omar (D-Minn.).

The broader crusade takes many forms, including allegations of fraud in immigration applications, illegal voting by noncitizens and misuse of federal benefits by immigrants who don't qualify.

"This administration has purposefully mischaracterized immigrants and asylum seekers as fraudsters," said Royce Murray, a former senior official at the Department of Homeland Security under the Biden administration. That, she said, "serves a narrative that immigrants are not to be trusted and are here to take something rather than contribute, with an end goal of trying to make Americans less welcoming and more comfortable with a mass deportation agenda."

On Tuesday, Trump and Vice President JD Vance announced a $25-million program under the Justice Department to encourage the public to report suspected fraud in the U.S. government.

The White House said the first check, for $10,000, will go to right-wing influencer Nick Shirley, who posted a video last year alleging that Somali residents in Minnesota were running fake child-care centers to collect federal subsidies. Dozens of people were convicted in connection with a sprawling, $250-million children's food assistance scheme that predated this administration, though more charges have been announced in recent months.

Also Tuesday, administration officials launched another nationwide anti-fraud crackdown, this time targeting immigrants who they allege have illegally collected SNAP benefits.

[See **Immigration,** A8]

BONTA, ESSAYLI CLASH ON HEALTH ARRESTS

California and U.S. officials duel over credit for charges in medical crackdown.

BY SONJA SHARP AND ANDREW J. CAMPA

California Atty. Gen. Rob Bonta and First Assistant U.S. Atty. Bill Essayli traded barbs at dueling healthcare fraud news conferences in downtown Los Angeles on Thursday morning, sniping at each other over billions lost to benefits schemes and the increasingly politicized efforts to stop them.

"California has a fraud problem," Essayli said at the 9:30 a.m. news conference, where he and a phalanx of federal investigators announced a sweeping takedown of doctors and others they say lured vulnerable patients into needless surgical procedures, sham treatment programs and bogus hospice care, bilking taxpayers out of nearly $2 billion.

"Whether it's hospice fraud or healthcare fraud or election fraud, California does fraud best," the prosecutor added, seeming to connect the cases with his office's simultaneous attempt to sequester midterm ballots it says were issued to noncitizens.

Bonta struck back at his own news conference across the street an hour later, saying Essayli had deliberately elided his team's contribution to the raid — including the arrest of a surgeon accused of performing unnecessary and invasive procedures for profit — part of what he termed a pattern of "improper politicization and weaponization" of medical fraud investigations.

"This isn't a political game for us," Bonta said. "This is about protecting taxpayer dollars, protecting the programs that sick and vulnerable Californians rely on, and protecting our

[See **Fraud,** A7]

Many Latinos in Texas are done with Trump

Voters are souring on GOP amid frustration over rising costs and harsh crackdowns on immigrants

By Ana Ceballos

EDINBURG, Texas — Clad in pressed jeans and cowboy hats, dozens of riders on horseback and drivers in pickups kicked up dust along a dirt road in Edinburg, near the southern tip of Texas. They were there for a *cabalgata*, a traditional horse procession, with a political message: Send Tejano singer Bobby Pulido to Congress.

Some were lifelong Democrats. Others had voted for President Trump two years ago. But on this Saturday, they all rode for Pulido, a Democrat trying to flip a House seat Trump carried by 18 percentage points in 2024.

Among them was David Lopez, 54, astride his brown horse, Black Jack. He voted for Trump because he saw him as a good businessman. But now, Lopez says the president's tariffs have hurt his truck and trailer repair shop in nearby McAllen, and business is down about 20% from last year.

"I am voting Democrats all the way. Trump is no longer doing a good job," Lopez said. "We need to find a way to make it out of this together."

Lopez is part of a shift rippling through Latino communities across the country. Two years after helping return Trump to the White House with a Republican-controlled Congress, Latino voters are souring on the party in power, fueled by frustration over rising costs and the administration's aggressive approach to immigration

[See **Latinos,** A6]

Courts rein in U.S. election actions

Unprecedented legal war plays out between the state and Trump administration.

BY KEVIN RECTOR

A sweeping campaign by federal immigration agents to identify voter fraud by noncitizens through door knocks, street stops and other field interviews in California and eight other states must be reined in ahead of the Nov. 3 election, after a federal judge in Northern California ruled it has intimidated U.S. citizens and interfered with the work of voting rights groups.

Judge Araceli Martínez-Olguin said in a ruling Wednesday that limiting the Department of Homeland Security's surging operations in those states — which she wrote "sweep in U.S. citizens for investigation" — does not prevent the Trump administration from "exercising their authority to investigate voter fraud by lawful means."

A Homeland Security spokesperson said the agency is "laser focused on identifying, prosecuting, and removing aliens who vote," and has "no plans to question or investigate people we believe to be U.S. citizens."

The ruling was the latest to come out of an unprecedented legal war playing out between the Trump administration and California in recent days, in which an array of election cases are working their way through the federal courts at breakneck speed.

There is, for example, the lawsuit the U.S. Justice Department filed against California and state and local elections officials last week, demanding that they set aside any ballots from a list of 20,000 individuals identified by immigration officials as "likely noncitizens."

There are two cases out of Washington, D.C., in which a coalition of Democratic leaders, immigrant rights groups, voting rights experts and naturalized citizens in California are challenging the Trump administration's use of Homeland Security data to target voters.

The litigation is playing out amid an intense political debate about election security at the national level — driven in part by President Trump, a longtime election

[See **Election,** A8]



MYUNG J. CHUN Los Angeles Times

THE AVERAGE L.A. County home is 58 years old, 16 older than the U.S. average.

L.A. rentals crumbling fast

Many affordable units probably will need upgrades, adding to county housing crisis.

BY JACK FLEMMING

Despite years of rising rents, Los Angeles County still has hundreds of thousands of affordable apartments.

But the region's cheapest rentals are also the oldest, and they'll probably need costly upgrades in the years ahead. Some units are crumbling to the point of being unlivable. Others are at risk of being torn down to make way for more profitable projects.

This marks a major challenge at a time when developers aren't building enough new housing to keep up with demand.

"It underscores a massive slowdown in construction over the past several decades," said USC research professor Jared Schachner, who co-wrote a Lusk Center for Real Estate study on aging affordable housing. "When you're not bringing in a large influx of units, that's the result: a large share of old buildings with a higher probability of being dilapidated."

As the L.A. area grapples with an affordability crisis, local governments have a tightrope to walk. Should they enact policies to preserve crumbling homes and keep rents down? Or should they encourage upgrades to the aging housing stock, bringing in more comfortable and energy-efficient, yet more expensive, properties?

As a metropolis, L.A. is relatively young compared

[See **Housing,** A12]

Iran says 7 tankers hit in Strait of Hormuz

BY MELANIE LIDMAN

TEL AVIV — Seven oil tankers caught fire or were damaged in the Strait of Hormuz overnight after being hit by Iran or striking naval mines, Tehran said Thursday, a markedly high number as tensions rise over concerns about a return to all-out war.

The United States is now sending more military assets to the region, including a third aircraft carrier and thousands of troops, to join the largest force of American warships and aircraft in the Middle East in decades.

With days before a close election in Israel in which Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu could lose power, and before next month's U.S. midterm election in which war-linked high prices have sparked voter anger, there are concerns that U.S.-Israeli attacks on Iran could resume.

"Netanyahu wants to attack Iran, that's not even a question," Danny Citrinowicz, a researcher at Israel's Institute for National Security Studies and a former Iran specialist in Israel's military and intelligence services, told the Associated Press.

He accused Israel of rushing into another round with Iran without revamping its strategy. A clear Netanyahu victory in the Oct. 27 election means an attack is almost guaranteed, he said.

Main opposition candidates are likely to focus on domestic issues first, but Citrinowicz said he believed the region is on the way

[See **Iran,** A3]

Deportations rise under Trump
Expected total of 660,000 over the last year is more than year prior but fewer than his target. **NATION, A5**

State may miss emissions targets
At the current rate, we could be years behind in reaching 2030 and 2045 reduction goals, data show. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Janelle Monáe's Halloween scene
The singer, songwriter, actor and author gets creative with costumes and parties around L.A. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather
Sun returning.
L.A. Basin: 73/58. **B6**

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ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

Walker Kessler (14) had 26 points in the victory.

New-look Lakers rule in the opener
Luka Doncic and his new center, Walker Kessler, waste little time clicking in 127-105 rout of Warriors. **SPORTS, B10**

Markets **A12**
Opinion Voices **A13**

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